



The Battle of Atlanta

Also called the Battle of Decatur, the pivotal July 22, 1864, engagement outside Atlanta was depicted in the 1880s, on one of the largest painted cycloramas in the world.

The final act

In late August, the Union army slipped out of its trenches at night and seemingly disappeared. At first baffled, Hood then discovered that his enemy had marched around the city and was approaching the Macon & Western Railroad at Jonesboro, 15 miles (24km) to the south. Desperately, Hood tried to counter the movement, but two days of fruitless assaults only resulted in thousands more Confederates being killed or maimed. The railroad was cut, and Atlanta was doomed.

Throughout the night of September 1, 1864, as Hood's army evacuated the city, the sky glowed red as fire devoured the supplies and depots they left behind. Nearly 80 freight cars of ammunition were burned; the din of their detonation continued for five hours. Ashes still drifted over the city when Sherman, on September 3, wired the president, "Atlanta is ours, and fairly won!"